ball – or tried to.

I'm sorry about that whole episode. Sure, emotions are important. They're good during an intense game. But having played for twenty years or so, it's fair to say that controlling emotions is a better bet than letting yourself go.

Was I ever terrified of a particular opponent? No. Not terrified. But there is one player who bothered me with what he could do. And he could do it all with his eyes.

Steve Waugh used to read players like a book. One look at a player and he would know what he was thinking. Even when his team would underperform, he would not give up and manage to deliver a win all by himself. They called him the 'Ice Man' and rightly so. He was always cool and calm, and it's brilliant how he knew the technique of individual batsmen and unleashed his bowlers on opponents accordingly. He was fearsome in the field. He would have made a great soldier. His tactics were his strategy and his strategy was to win, all the time, even against the odds.

As for inspiration, even though I believe that man is his own best friend and his own worst enemy, of course, legends help. They say that I'm the biggest star in Pakistan since Imran Khan. Whoever they are, they are too kind. It's great that I'm compared to an ideal I used to dream about. Imran Khan's 'Pathanpana', his Pashtun-ness, his Mianwali roots, his style, his belligerence in the field – a Pashtun trait he has carried into politics – were all very inspiring during my growing-up years. From his unbelievably athletic run-up to the craze he stirred in that era of cricket to his genuine superstardom, everything about Imran made me want to be an aggressive Pakistani cricketer.

Wasim Akram, another legend of the game, treated me like a younger brother, as did Moin Khan, Saeed Anwar and Inzamam-ul-Haq. For the teenage kid that I was, even hanging out with such stars was a dream come true. Playing with them, learning the game from them was beyond a dream. These guys are unforgettable.

If Imran was my hero, Wasim was my mentor. Fighting hard on the field, living easy off it, he is a man who demanded everything on the field and nothing outside it. During matches, he would break my back. After them, he would help me shop, put my wardrobe together, party and hang out with me like he was a schoolmate – even though he was the skipper.

My biggest lesson from Wasim bhai: fight till the end in a match. Surviving out there was – is – everything. Without a fight, there is no cricket. And without cricket, there is no purpose to life. Not for him and not for me.

There were other mentors along the way too. There was Saeed Anwar, my favourite batsman till date. He told me to never leave my core strength – power hitting. Slashing out. Whenever I was in doubt about my batting, I thought of Saeed bhai's advice and bounced back.

Of course, I was lucky to have played alongside my fellow Pathan, Younis Khan. What a hard worker! Not a talented or naturally gifted cricketer, of course, but Younis showed the world that you can go far, very far, with basic cricketing skills.

I must also mention my fellow Karachiite, Moin Khan. If there's anyone who taught me how to hike up morale, on and off the field, it was him. How to deal with the younger guys, how to motivate a bowler, how to get the team into a huddle and decide what next – I learnt a lot from him. Moin is the perfect wingman. He is also a kind man. We have done a lot of voluntary aid and development work together.